

IELTS Writing: Template Trap Pack

Book 8 · Stop memorised openings that cap your score

Stratum IELTS · stratumielts.com

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Part of the Stratum IELTS Writing Guide Series

Who this book is for

You watched YouTube tips.

You saved "Band 9 templates".

Your essays still sit at **6.0–6.5**.

This book attacks a major student pain: **robot templates that examiners recognise instantly**.

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1. Why templates feel safe (and fail)

Templates reduce panic. That is why they spread on YouTube.

But problems start when students:

- paste the same intro for every question
- force "Firstly / Moreover / In a nutshell" in every paragraph
- use memorised hooks that ignore the task
- write body starters that fit *any* topic (so they fit none)

Examiners look for **task-specific answers**, not recycled openings.

Goal of this book: keep structure, drop the script.

2. Template red flags

If your essay often contains these, rewrite:

Red flag	Why it hurts
<i>In this contemporary epoch...</i>	Fake academic tone
<i>It is a highly debatable topic...</i>	Empty, not task-linked
<i>First and foremost... Moreover... Additionally... spam</i>	Mechanical cohesion
Fixed 3-body-paragraph script always	Wastes time; shallow ideas
Memorised conclusion with no link to your position	Weak Task Response
Fake statistics (<i>According to a recent survey, 78%...</i>)	Looks invented
Forced idioms in formal essays	Unnatural lexical resource

Quick test: cover the question. If your intro could fit 20 different prompts, it is a template trap.

3. Flexible patterns (not scripts)

Use **jobs**, not fixed sentences.

Introduction pattern (2–3 sentences)

1. Paraphrase *this* topic in your own words
2. Answer the task directly (position / preview)

Opinion example shape

[Paraphrase]. I largely agree because [reason A] and [reason B].

Discussion example shape

Some people argue A, while others believe B. This essay examines both views and explains why I support [view].

Change the words every time. Keep only the logic.

Body paragraph pattern

1. Topic sentence = one idea
2. Explanation
3. Specific example
4. Link back to the question

No required starter like *Firstly*.
Start with the idea itself.

Conclusion pattern

Restate position + summarise two ideas.
No new argument. No dramatic idiom.

4. Rewrite lab

Intro rewrite

Template version

In this modern era, the issue of unpaid community service has become a bone of contention. This essay will shed light on both sides before delineating my perspective.

Natural version

Some people believe unpaid community service should be compulsory in high schools. I largely agree, because it builds social awareness and practical skills when the workload stays realistic.

Body starter rewrite

Template version

First and foremost, it is widely acknowledged that this phenomenon has numerous merits.

Natural version

The main benefit is that students meet community needs beyond their own lives.

Conclusion rewrite

Template version

In a nutshell, after weighing the pros and cons, I pen down that every coin has two sides.

Natural version

In conclusion, I support compulsory school service in limited hours, because it develops responsibility and useful skills.

5. Safe practice method

Week plan

Day	Task
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1	Take 3 old intros → rewrite without template phrases
2	Write 2 timed essays using only “jobs” (no memorised lines)
3	Highlight every linker; delete half of them
4	Replace one fake statistic with a concrete scenario
5	Full timed essay + checklist (Book 5)
6	Check at stratumielts.com and rewrite once
7	Build your personal “banned phrases” list

Your banned list starter

- contemporary epoch
- bone of contention
- shed light on
- pen down
- every coin has two sides
- according to a recent survey (unless real and necessary — usually skip)

6. Next step on Stratum IELTS

1. Paste your latest essay into <https://stratumielts.com>
2. Ask: does feedback mention generic/template language?
3. Rewrite only the introduction and first body paragraph in natural style
4. Compare both versions

If ideas are the real blocker, use **Book 7: No Ideas Pack**.

If score is stuck after fixing templates, use **Book 6: Stuck at 6.5**.

Pocket rule

Structure = yes. Script = no.

Same paragraph jobs. Fresh sentences every essay.

About this booklet

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